Akbar’s studios there were some of the most talented painters of the time, at the peak of their artistic powers. Artists like Miskin, so compassionate in his paintings of animals that he captured not only their physical exertions and muscularity but even their inner, desperate fears. And Basawan, who perfected his art at the Mughal court over more than thirty years, using his ‘psychologically acute… characterizations, painterliness, three-dimensional treatment of space, and swelling roundness of form’ to create works of astounding realism and subtlety.

There would have been Manohar Das, too, Basawan’s young son, around Salim’s age, who would have carefully observed Akbar and all the formidable courtiers at Lahore, and who would paint tender and vulnerable images of the ageing Padshah in the following decades. Manohar grew up observing and adopting each changing nuance in the artistic tenor of the court, and while not possessing the genius of some of the greatest artists, he stands out ‘as a humble, painterly artist whose arabesques and drapery cavort and ripple with released vitality and express the joy he found in his work’. The art historian John Seyller has argued that Basawan began promoting Manohar as an artist at around this time. There is a portrait of Manohar that has survived. It shows a smooth-faced, large-eyed, and slightly chubby young boy dated to this period believed to be one of only three self-portraits of sixteenth-century Mughal India. Seyller believes this was in fact a joint work between father and son, Basawan wishing to promote the talents of his son, probably not imagining that his son’s fame would far outshine his at the courts of Jahangir and then Shah Jahan. And then there were outliers, like Farrukh Husain, a Persian painter at the Safavid court who left Isfahan to first work at Mirza Hakim’s court at Kabul. Considered by art historians to be one of the most underrated artists of Mughal painting, he joined the Mughal court in 1585, when he was already a mature forty-year-old artist. He was much admired and given the title Farrukh Beg. At the Mughal court, Farrukh Beg was initially paired up with the artists Dharmadas and Dhanraj, to work on the *Khamsa of Nizami*. However, after this work, it was understood that Farrukh Beg preferred to work alone and this contemplative, enigmatic, and singular artist was allowed the quite exceptional privilege from 1586–96, to work on illustrations on his own. He created works of remarkable sophistication and delicacy, with a clear penchant for lissom youths and swaying cypresses.